CARDIFF, UNITED KINGDOM

National Museum Cardiff: Masterpieces

Twenty paintings connecting Welsh landscapes, occupied interiors and figures with a task.



Snow changes the arrangement of a Paris district; a pool of light makes part of Ewenny Priory legible; a tidal shore becomes ground that people and cattle must cross. These works treat a setting as something with conditions. Weather, routes and illumination affect what can happen within it and how much of it can be seen.

The selection also brings that attention indoors and close to individual figures. A painter holds the tools of his profession, children occupy a classroom in different ways, and card players watch one another. Landscape and portraiture meet in the practical question of how a person belongs to a place.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-museum-cardiff

The selection · 20

1. Effect of Snow at Petit-Montrouge
   Édouard Manet · 1870
2. Transept of Ewenny Priory
   J. M. W. Turner · c. 1797
3. Carneddau Mountains from Pencerrig
   Thomas Jones · c. 1776
4. Saint Peter
   El Greco · c. 1610
5. Landscape with Saint Philip Baptizing the Eunuch
   Claude Lorrain · 1678
6. Hagar and Ishmael in the Wilderness
   Andrea Sacchi · c. 1630
7. The Sacrifice of Jephthah’s Daughter
   John Everett Millais · 1867
8. Fair Rosamund, Study
   John William Waterhouse · 1916
9. Richard Wilson
   Anton Raphael Mengs · 1752
10. Crossing the Sands to Swansea Market
    Edward Francis Drew Pritchard · 1856
11. Board School Children
    Barnett Samuel Marks · 1874
12. Griffith Owen, Harpist to the Corbet Family
    Benjamin Marshall · c. 1812
13. The Bal Maidens
    Emily Mary Osborn · c. 1870
14. Girl in a Field
    George Clausen · c. 1900
15. Cilgerran Castle
    William Havell · c. 1805
16. Pozzuoli
    Penry Williams · 1831
17. Sgwd yr Henryd, Vale of Neath
    Penry Williams · 1819
18. Mass for the Reapers
    Penry Williams · 1858
19. Innocents and Card Sharpers
    Ernest Meissonier · 1861
20. La Parisienne
    Pierre-Auguste Renoir · 1874

01 / 20

Effect of Snow at Petit-Montrouge

Édouard Manet

1870 · National Museum Cardiff



Édouard Manet. Effect of Snow at Petit-Montrouge. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The snow appears in patches between broad shapes of building rather than as an even covering over a detailed map. A spire helps keep the district identifiable beneath the ochre-grey sky. Manet allows the weather to reorganise the place: distinctions of light and dark become more decisive than an inventory of its architecture.

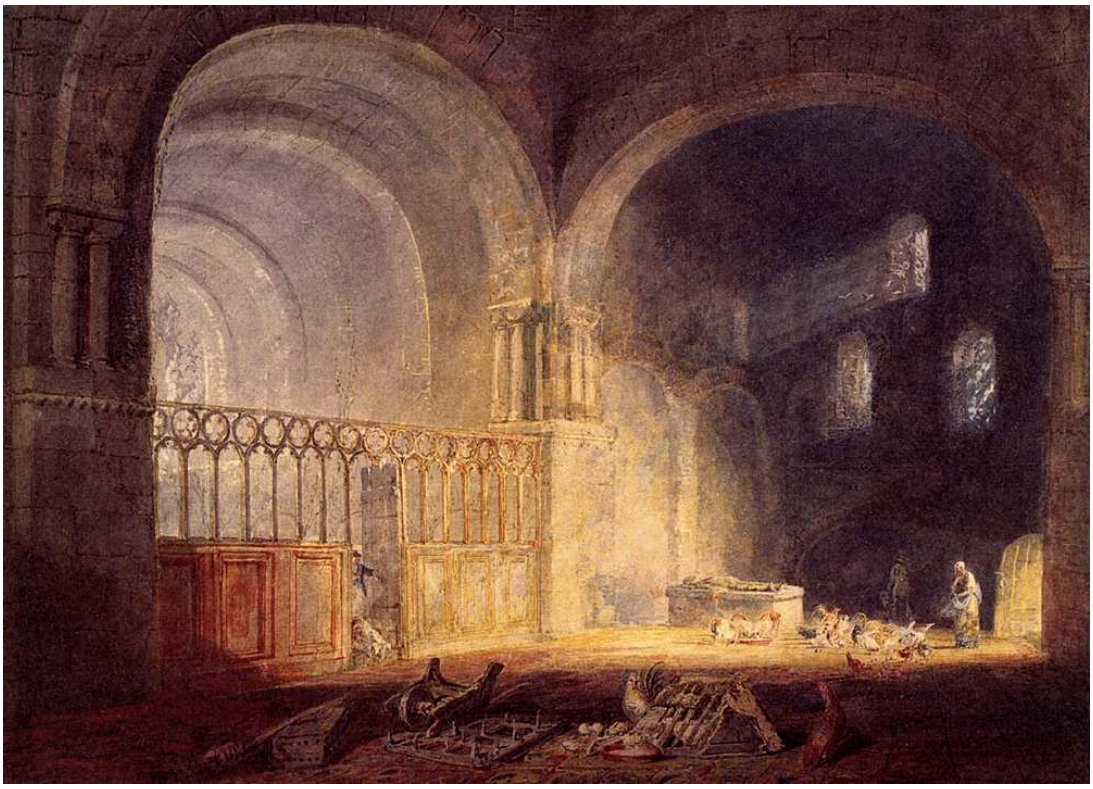
Object source · Open artwork

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Transept of Ewenny Priory

J. M. W. Turner

c. 1797 · National Museum Cardiff



J. M. W. Turner. Transept of Ewenny Priory, Glamorganshire. Image credit: J. M. W. Turner. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The church does not disclose all its structure at once. Light catches parts of the screen and floor while upper walls and recesses remain harder to read. Turner gives looking a sequence within the interior. Understanding the building requires passing between illuminated surfaces and what their neighbouring shadows withhold.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Carneddau Mountains from Pencerrig

Thomas Jones

c. 1776 · National Museum Cardiff



Thomas Jones. Carneddau Mountains from Pencerrig. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/thomas-jones/carneddau-mountains-from-pencerrig-1776 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Tracks and field divisions keep the slopes attached to human use, even as the view extends toward distant ridges. The museum identifies this as the landscape near Jones’s family home at Pencerrig. That specificity matters: the painting’s ordered distances belong to an encountered place, not merely a generalised idea of mountain scenery.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Saint Peter

El Greco

c. 1610 · National Museum Cardiff



El Greco. St. Peter. Image credit: El Greco. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The lifted hand is a second centre beside the pale face. Blue drapery and elongated forms connect them within an otherwise restrained setting of cloud and shadow. The title identifies Saint Peter, but the immediate encounter is built from bodily attention: a turn, an upward tension and a gesture held close to the chest.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMW A 3915

05 / 20

Landscape with Saint Philip Baptizing the Eunuch

Claude Lorrain

1678 · National Museum Cardiff



Claude Lorrain. Landscape with St. Philip Baptizing the Eunuch. Image credit: Claude Lorrain; Source credit: Princeton Art Museum. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The figures beside the carriage occupy only a small part of the landscape. Tall trees give the baptism a sheltered setting, while the open distance preserves the larger journey around it. Claude does not need to enlarge the event to give it a place; the extensive world continues beyond the travellers' immediate encounter.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Hagar and Ishmael in the Wilderness

Andrea Sacchi

c. 1630 · National Museum Cardiff



Andrea Sacchi. Hagar and Ishmael in the Wilderness. Image credit: Andrea Sacchi. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The woman supports the child while the angel’s gesture directs attention outward. Hands and glances connect the close bodily crisis to another part of the landscape. The curving group fits the shaped canvas, keeping the figures related even as their attention begins to move beyond the suffering pair.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMW A 9

07 / 20

The Sacrifice of Jephthah’s Daughter

John Everett Millais

1867 · National Museum Cardiff



John Everett Millais. Sacrifice of Jephthah’s Daughter. Image credit: John Everett Millais. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The embracing young woman and seated armed man establish affectionate contact, but the biblical story gives that meeting a fatal consequence. The surrounding responses prevent the embrace from being read in isolation. Millais makes the encounter difficult through the gap between a visible gesture of welcome and knowledge of the vow that burdens it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMW A 180

08 / 20

Fair Rosamund, Study

John William Waterhouse

1916 · National Museum Cardiff



John William Waterhouse. Fair Rosamund (study). Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The woman’s attention passes toward the window, but its destination is withheld. Patterned textile, tiled floor and surrounding decoration make the interior more available than whatever lies outside. The study gives waiting a direction without resolving its object, keeping the figure’s look in tension with the room that contains her.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Richard Wilson

Anton Raphael Mengs

1752 · National Museum Cardiff



Anton Raphael Mengs. Richard Wilson. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/anton-raphael-mengs/richard-wilson-1752 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Palette and brushes identify Wilson’s occupation without requiring a studio full of supporting evidence. The soft cap and turned face keep the encounter close, while warm clothing separates him from the greenish ground. Mengs gives professional identity a modest physical form: the tools remain at hand rather than becoming a theatrical display.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Crossing the Sands to Swansea Market

Edward Francis Drew Pritchard

1856 · National Museum Cardiff



Edward Francis Drew Pritchard. Crossing the Sands to Swansea Market. Image credit: Edward Francis Drew Pritchard; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The procession of people and cattle is small in relation to the shore it crosses. The market named in the title gives the movement a destination, while water, boats and broad sky keep that purpose within a tidal landscape. Trade has a distance to travel, not merely a place of sale.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMW A 522

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Board School Children

Barnett Samuel Marks

1874 · National Museum Cardiff



Barnett Samuel Marks. Board School Children. Image credit: Barnett Samuel Marks; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The children occupy a shared classroom without sharing a single state of attention. Books, turned faces and hands distinguish reading, waiting and looking elsewhere. Benches hold the group together, but do not erase those differences. Marks makes schooling visible as a situation lived by several bodies rather than one idealised pupil.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMW A 4971

12 / 20

Griffith Owen, Harpist to the Corbet Family

Benjamin Marshall

c. 1812 · National Museum Cardiff



Benjamin Marshall. Griffith Owen (1750–1833), Harpist to the Corbet Family of Ynysymaengwyn. Image credit: Benjamin Marshall; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The harp's curved structure rises above and around its player, giving his profession a substantial place in the portrait. A hand near the strings indicates a practical relationship without requiring a performance to be in progress. The instrument is both identifying object and compositional partner, shaping how the figure occupies the space.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMW A 14301

13 / 20

The Bal Maidens

Emily Mary Osborn

c. 1870 · National Museum Cardiff



Emily Mary Osborn. The Bal Maidens. Image credit: Emily Mary Osborn; Source credit: Art UK : entry 160807. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The loads make work visible through the women’s posture even as they walk away from a workplace. Aprons and head coverings distinguish individuals within their shared forward movement. Osborn keeps the group together without making the three women copies of one type: carrying is a common condition, not a complete personal identity.

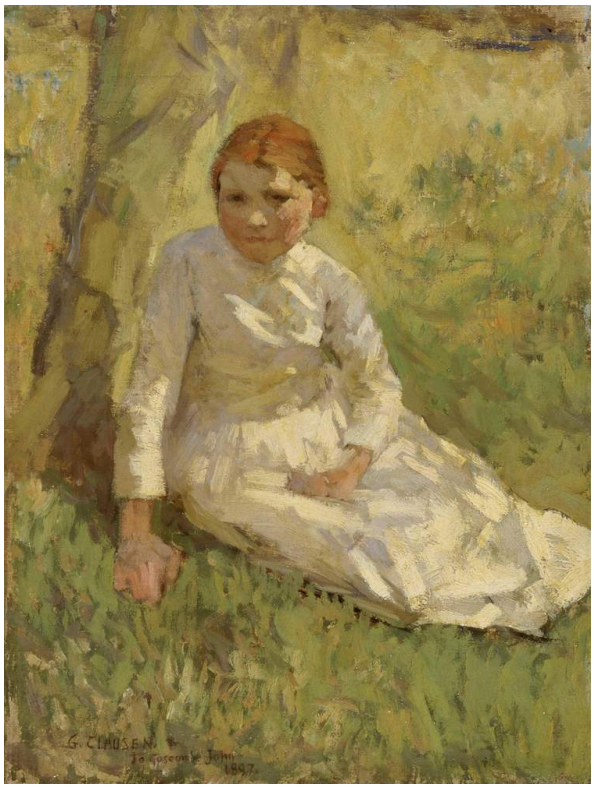
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMW A 5012

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Girl in a Field

George Clausen

c. 1900 · National Museum Cardiff



George Clausen. Girl in a Field. Image credit: George Clausen. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The girl sits low enough for the grass and its broken light to surround her. Her comparatively still figure remains distinct without being cut off from the field’s loose marks. Clausen allows person and setting to receive a related treatment, making outdoor light something shared rather than a background effect.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMW A 175

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Cilgerran Castle

William Havell

c. 1805 · National Museum Cardiff



William Havell. Cilgerran Castle. Image credit: William Havell; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The castle is approached along the river, through wooded banks and shadowed foreground boats. Its height becomes intelligible in relation to that lower route. Havell lets historical architecture belong to the terrain around it instead of giving the monument a separate, unobstructed stage.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMW A 475

16 / 20

Pozzuoli

Penry Williams

1831 · Oil on canvas · National Museum Cardiff



Penry Williams. Pozzuoli. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/penry-williams/pozzuoli-1831 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Animals and rough ground give the near slope a texture distinct from the broad water beyond. Buildings along the far shore establish a settlement without closing the bay. Williams makes the coastal prospect depend on this change of scale: close things require separate attention, while distance can be held together in larger areas.

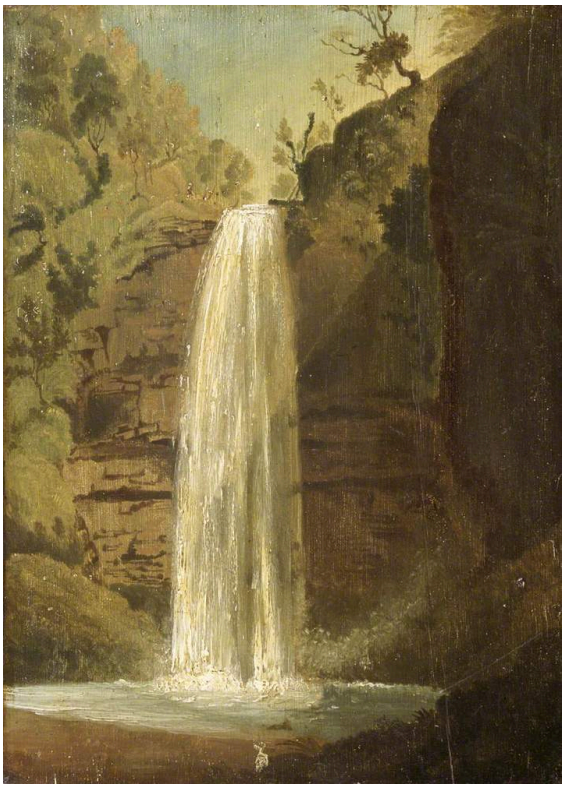
Object source · Open artwork

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Sgwd yr Henryd, Vale of Neath

Penry Williams

1819 · Oil on board · National Museum Cardiff



Penry Williams. Sgwd yr Henryd, Vale of Neath. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/penry-williams/sgwd-yr-henryd-vale-of-neath-1819 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The waterfall’s pale descent is sharply distinguished from dark rock and vegetation. The narrow space reinforces the downward direction, giving the water little room to spread sideways. Williams relies on that difference in light to establish the fall’s course while the enclosing cliff gives it height.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Mass for the Reapers

Penry Williams

1858 · National Museum Cardiff



Penry Williams. Mass for the Reapers. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The chapel is modest beside the gathering around it. Bright clothing, resting bodies and the surrounding fields connect observance to the agricultural day. The group does not leave work's landscape for a monumental church interior; the religious occasion takes its place within the ground and time of the reapers.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Innocents and Card Sharpers

Ernest Meissonier

1861 · National Museum Cardiff



Ernest Meissonier. Innocents and Card Sharpers (A Game of Piquet). Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The players watch cards and one another at close range, with little space left between hats, hands and faces. The title establishes deception, but its progress has to be read through unequal attention. Meissonier makes looking part of the contest, rather than offering the spectator a single large gesture that explains everything.

Object source · Open artwork

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La Parisienne

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

1874 · Oil · National Museum Cardiff



Pierre-Auguste Renoir. La Parisienne ("The Blue Lady"). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pierre-auguste-renoir/la-parisienne-the-blue-lady · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The blue dress and matching hat give the standing woman a public presence while the setting remains lightly stated. Small shifts of light distinguish parts of the costume without breaking its overall shape. Her gloved hands supply a contained action near the waist, holding the figure together without an elaborate surrounding narrative.

Object source · Open artwork

Follow a task through its setting

Compare the crossing to Swansea market with the bal maidens' loads and the harpist's instrument. Each makes work visible through a different relation between body and surroundings. The catalogue includes works that may be in store; consult current Museum Wales information before treating this selection as a visit plan.

Further reading

Impressionism: A Centenary Exhibition

Anne Dayez, Michel Hoog and Charles S. Moffett · Read online or download · English

The catalogue supplies context for Manet's snow scene and Renoir's La Parisienne. Their different uses of a lightly described setting become clearer beside the more detailed landscapes and interiors in this guide.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12